Chapter 8
A Light Has Gone Out

Gandhi had helped bring about independence. His weapons to free India had been love and truth. But Gandhi's hopes could not solve all of the country's problems. Hindus and Muslims clashed violently.

After the creation of Pakistan, millions of Muslims and Hindus had to move from their homes and cross the new border between the countries. Muslims in East Punjab had to flee to the west (the new Pakistan). Hindus had to move from west to east. Throughout 1947, violent massacres occurred between the groups. Hundreds of thousands of people were killed.

In big cities, such as Calcutta and Delhi, riots continued between the religious groups as well. On January 13, 1948, Gandhi began a fast to try to get them to stop. He did not even drink water. He was in pain. But even curled up in bed, he led a prayer meeting. Gandhi's prayers were broadcast by radio and heard over all of India. After five days of negotiations, both Hindu and Muslim political leaders came before Gandhi and agreed to his terms. They did not want to see Gandhi suffer.